

BETTER VICE CLUB

Learn.WitUS Curriculum

CentenarianOS Academy

Episode 3

Chocolate

"The Food of the Gods"

Economics

Teacher Curriculum Packet

Pilot Edition | 2026-2027

How Better Vice Club Works

Better Vice Club (BVC) is a podcast curriculum that teaches Geography, Social Studies, Economics, and English Language Arts through global commodities. Each episode follows a single substance from its geographic origin through its history, economics, and the literature it has generated. Your packet isolates your subject so you can use it standalone, or coordinate with other departments for a full interdisciplinary unit.

What You Need

- Episode audio linked on the Episode Overview page. Episodes run 35 to 40 minutes. You can use the full episode or specific segments called CUT POINTS.
- This packet. All student-facing materials are here, ready to print or share digitally.
- No additional materials required for core activities.

CUT POINTS

Each episode is divided into labeled segments. You don't need to play the full episode. CUT-3D is the Economics segment; CUT-3E is ELA, and so on. Start times are on the Episode Overview page.

The Four BVC Patterns

These patterns repeat across all three seasons of BVC covering 21 episodes:

- Geography Insists. The physical landscape determines what can grow and how.
- Cultivation Begins Sacred. Most commodities begin as ceremonial practice before they become commercial products.
- Labor Captures the Smallest Share. Producers earn the least. Brands and retailers earn the most.
- What Gets Burned, What Gets Saved. Who controls the narrative about a commodity shapes its history.

BVC is produced by Anthony McDonald in Indianapolis, Indiana. All content is documented with peer-reviewed APA citations. No fabricated stories or unnamed expert characters appear in any episode. The curriculum brand is Learn.WitUS, hosted at CentenarianOS.com/academy.

Episode 3 Overview: Chocolate

Detail	Information
Episode title	The Food of the Gods
Season	Season 1: Daily Rituals
Full runtime	35 to 40 minutes
Subjects	Geography, Social Studies, Economics, ELA (all four in one episode)
Audio access	CentenarianOS.com/academy or ask your BVC contact for the file
Recommended grade	9 to 12 (Indiana Academic Standards aligned)

Segment Map

Use CUT POINTS to navigate directly to your subject without playing the full episode.

Cut ID	Segment Title	Start Time	Duration	Subject
CUT-3A	Cold Open: The Price of Gods	0:00	2 min	All subjects
CUT-3B	The Cacao Belt	2:00	8 min	Geography
CUT-3C	From Sacred Drink to Slave Trade	10:00	8 min	Social Studies
CUT-3D	The \$161 Billion Bar	18:00	8 min	Economics
CUT-3E	The Gods Write Back	26:00	8 min	ELA
CUT-3F	The Conscious Bar (Closing)	34:00	2 min	All subjects

Episode Summary

Episode 3 follows cacao from Mayan ceremonial centers in Mesoamerica, where it was currency and sacred drink, through the colonial plantation economy that moved production to West Africa, to a \$161.5 billion global industry where Ivory Coast farmers earn less than \$1 per day. The episode asks why the people who grow chocolate have never tasted it.

Cross-curricular note: If colleagues in other departments are also piloting BVC, their students are studying the same episode through different lenses. Episode 3 connects directly to Episode 1 (Coffee) and Episode 4 (Sugar) as part of a three-episode arc on colonial commodities.

Economics Vocabulary

Introduce these terms before the Economics segment (CUT-3D, starting at 18:00).

Term	Definition	Chocolate Application
Commodity market	A global trading system for standardized raw materials with prices set by supply and demand.	Cacao is traded on the London International Financial Futures Exchange. Price changes there affect farmers in Ivory Coast immediately.
Value capture	The portion of the final sale price that each stage of the supply chain keeps.	Cacao farmers keep 3 to 6 percent of the final \$3 chocolate bar price.
Smile curve	Economic model showing value capture is highest at the supply chain's endpoints (branding and retail) and lowest in the physical middle (farming).	The Ivory Coast farmer earns \$0.50 to \$0.84 per day. Nestle and Mars earn billions marketing and selling the product.
Fair Trade certification	A certification system guaranteeing minimum prices, community development premiums, and prohibition of child labor.	Fair Trade cacao commands \$2,600 per metric ton plus a \$240 premium. Only 3.2 percent of global cacao is Fair Trade certified.
Living wage gap	The difference between what producers earn and what they need to cover basic household expenses.	85 percent of cacao farming families in Ivory Coast live below the poverty line.
True cost accounting	An economic approach that includes the full social and environmental costs of production in a product's price.	If chocolate's true cost included a living wage for all farmers, a \$3 bar would cost approximately \$3.45, a 15 percent increase.
Market concentration	When a small number of companies control a large share of a market.	Mars, Nestle, Mondelez, Ferrero, Lindt, and Hershey control over 60 percent of global chocolate retail.

Child labor (economic framing)	When poverty-level household incomes make children's labor economically necessary for family survival. A structural economic condition, not just individual moral failure.	85 percent of cacao farming families in Ivory Coast live in poverty. Child labor is a predictable consequence of farm gate prices that don't sustain households.
Externalized cost	A cost created by a producer that is paid by people outside the market transaction.	Cacao monoculture causes deforestation. The ecological cost is borne by ecosystems and future generations, not by chocolate companies.
Monopsony	Market structure where there's only one buyer for a product, giving that buyer enormous price-setting power.	In some West African cacao regions, national marketing boards function as monopsonies, limiting farmers' ability to negotiate better prices.

Economics Data Sheet: The \$161 Billion Bar

Global Chocolate Market Overview (2024)

Metric	Figure	Context
Total global market value	\$161.5 billion	Larger than the global coffee market. Chocolate is the world's most popular confection.
Annual cacao production	5.2 million metric tonnes	Limited by the narrow Cacao Belt. Can't be grown in most of the world.
Farmer's share of a \$3 chocolate bar	3 to 6 percent (\$0.09 to \$0.18)	The farmer who grew the cacao receives less than 20 cents on a \$3 bar.
Ivory Coast farmer daily income	\$0.50 to \$0.84 per day	For the world's largest cacao producer (42% of global supply).
Children in cacao labor (ILO, 2020)	1.56 million	95 percent exposed to hazardous working conditions.
Fair Trade market share (global)	3.2%	97 percent of global chocolate is produced without Fair Trade certification.
True cost of living-wage chocolate	Approximately +15 percent (\$0.45 more on a \$3 bar)	Calculated by researchers estimating what living wages for all cacao farmers would add to retail prices.

Supply Chain Value Distribution: The \$3 Chocolate Bar

Stage	Actor	Pct of \$3 Bar	Dollars from \$3 Bar	Notes
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1. Farming	Smallholder farmer (Ivory Coast, Ghana)	3 to 6%	\$0.09 to \$0.18	The physically essential, lowest-paid stage
2. Trading and export	Commodities trader and exporter	8 to 12%	\$0.24 to \$0.36	Buys from many farmers; sells to processors
3. Processing	Industrial processor (often Netherlands or Germany)	12 to 18%	\$0.36 to \$0.54	85% of processing in consuming countries
4. Manufacturing	Chocolate manufacturer (Nestle, Mars, Hershey)	35 to 40%	\$1.05 to \$1.20	Conching, tempering, molding, packaging
5. Marketing and retail	Retailer (grocery, specialty, online)	30 to 35%	\$0.90 to \$1.05	Shelf placement, advertising, brand premium
6. Government taxes	Local, state, federal	5 to 8%	\$0.15 to \$0.24	Varies significantly by country

The smile curve applied to chocolate: the farmer at Stage 1 earns 3 to 6 percent. The manufacturer and retailer at Stages 4 and 5 together earn 65 to 75 percent. The farmer's labor is irreplaceable. The brand's marketing is not. Yet the brand captures more value in one year of advertising than a farmer earns in a lifetime of growing.

Fair Trade Economics: Does Certification Work?

Metric	Fair Trade Farms	Conventional Farms	Difference
Child labor prevalence	12%	31%	Fair Trade farms show a 19 percentage point reduction
Farmer income premium	\$2,600 + \$240/metric ton	\$2,400 to \$2,800/metric ton	Modest income improvement, especially during price crashes

School attendance (children)	78%	58%	20 percentage point improvement
Forest cover maintained	67% more tree cover	Baseline	Significant environmental benefit
Global market share	3.2%	96.8%	Fair Trade reaches a small fraction of all cacao farmers
Growth rate (2020 to 2024)	12.8% annually	4.5% overall market	Growing faster than conventional, but from a very small base

Indiana connection: Indianapolis grocery stores carry both Fair Trade and conventional chocolate. If all Indianapolis residents switched to Fair Trade (typically \$0.50 to \$1.00 more per bar), the additional personal cost would amount to less than a movie ticket per year, while generating roughly \$2 to \$3 million in additional Fair Trade premium revenue directed toward cacao farming communities.

Economics Activity: The True Cost of a Chocolate Bar

Time: 35 to 40 minutes. Materials: this packet plus a calculator. Optional: physical chocolate bars at various price points.

Part 1: Supply Chain Math (15 minutes)

Students calculate what each actor earns from a \$3 chocolate bar, then compare those amounts to the work involved at each stage.

- Farmer's share at 3 to 6 percent: \$0.09 to \$0.18. How many \$3 bars would a farmer need to sell (in terms of beans grown) to earn \$1.00?
- The manufacturer's share at 35 to 40 percent: \$1.05 to \$1.20 per bar. If Mars sells 3 billion bars per year, what is Mars's approximate supply-chain revenue from bar sales alone?
- What's the ratio between the farmer's daily income (\$0.50 to \$0.84) and the manufacturer's approximate daily revenue from bar sales? What does that ratio mean?

Part 2: The Living Wage Calculation (10 minutes)

Researchers estimate that if cacao farmers received a living wage (approximately \$6.00 per day in Ivory Coast vs. the current \$0.50 to \$0.84), a \$3 chocolate bar would cost approximately \$3.45, a 15 percent increase.

- Is 15 percent enough of a price increase to justify avoiding child labor and poverty-level wages? What factors influence your answer?
- A standard Fair Trade premium adds roughly \$0.50 to \$1.00 to a chocolate bar's retail price. Compare this to the living wage calculation. Is the Fair Trade premium sufficient to close the gap to a living wage? Why or why not?
- Tony's Chocolonely, a Dutch chocolate company, explicitly structures its supply chain to pay farmers above living wages. Its bars cost roughly \$4.50 to \$6.00 compared to \$1.50 to \$3.00 for conventional brands. Does this prove ethical chocolate is economically viable? What assumptions is that argument making?

Part 3: The Certification Gap (10 minutes)

Only 3.2 percent of global cacao is Fair Trade certified. Students explore why:

- Fair Trade certification has upfront costs that small farmers may struggle to afford. If certification costs \$500 per cooperative and the Fair Trade premium is \$240 per metric ton, how many metric tons does a cooperative need to sell to break even on certification costs?
- Why don't more consumers choose Fair Trade chocolate if it produces better outcomes? What economic and behavioral factors explain the 3.2 percent market share ceiling?
- A critic argues: the Fair Trade model requires ethical consumers to voluntarily pay more for an outcome that should be mandatory through regulation. Do you agree? What would mandatory living wages for cacao farmers require of governments and companies?

Discussion Questions

- Is the smile curve an inevitable feature of global commodity supply chains, or is it a political and policy choice that's maintained because it benefits powerful interests?
- If living-wage chocolate costs 15 percent more and the entire cost falls on consumers, who bears that cost disproportionately, and is that a just distribution?

Economics Knowledge Checks

Use as an exit ticket, short quiz, or discussion prompt. Answer key follows.

1. Using data from the supply chain table, explain the smile curve as it applies to chocolate. Which stage captures the most value, which captures the least, and what does the farmer's position reveal about how global commodity supply chains distribute economic value?

2. 1.56 million children work in West African cacao. Using the economics data, explain this as a structural problem connected to supply chain value distribution, not simply individual moral failure by farming families or chocolate companies.

3. Fair Trade cacao significantly reduces child labor prevalence (12 percent vs. 31 percent on conventional farms) yet holds only 3.2 percent of the global cacao market. Using economic reasoning, explain why Fair Trade hasn't grown faster and what would be required to change this.

Answer Key (teacher reference only)

Q1 expected answer:

Smile curve: value capture is highest at endpoints (manufacturing and retail, which together capture 65 to 75 percent) and lowest in the physical middle (farming, at 3 to 6 percent). From the table: farmers earn \$0.09 to \$0.18 from a \$3 bar; manufacturers earn \$1.05 to \$1.20 and retailers earn \$0.90 to \$1.05. The farmer's labor is irreplaceable yet captures the smallest economic margin. Students must use specific percentage and dollar figures.

Q2 expected answer:

Structural explanation: (1) colonial trade established West African cacao as a low-wage export commodity with pricing controlled by European trading companies; (2) current farm gate prices put 85 percent of farming families below the poverty line; (3) at those income levels, households need all members' labor for survival; (4) the companies capturing 65 to 75 percent of bar value haven't raised farmer prices proportionally to their profits. Child labor is the predictable economic outcome of that pricing structure. Families aren't choosing it freely; they're responding rationally to conditions they didn't create.

Q3 expected answer:

Fair Trade grows slowly because: (1) certification costs are prohibitive for the smallest farmers; (2) consumers are price-sensitive and many won't pay even a 15 to 20 percent premium for ethical sourcing; (3) conventional chocolate companies compete aggressively on price; (4) most consumers don't regularly think about the supply chain behind their chocolate. Growing faster would require mandatory sourcing standards (removing consumer choice as the mechanism), subsidies for farmer certification costs, or significant consumer education driving demand shifts. The current model relies on individual consumer ethics, which reaches only a small premium segment.

Indiana Economics Standards Alignment

Standard	Description	Where Addressed
E.1.1	Explain how scarcity, choice, and opportunity cost affect economic decisions	Fair Trade vs. conventional sourcing; farmer income vs. family survival trade-offs
E.1.3	Analyze market structures and how they affect prices	Commodity market structure; Fair Trade as alternative; market concentration among major brands
E.2.2	Explain the role of prices in allocating resources	Cacao farm gate prices driving child labor; Fair Trade price floors
E.2.4	Describe how supply and demand determine market prices	Narrow Cacao Belt limiting supply; climate change risks to future supply
E.4.2	Analyze how trade affects the U.S. and global economy	Chocolate supply chain; value capture in consuming vs. producing countries
E.4.5	Describe how economic indicators measure economic performance	Living wage gap as economic indicator; Fair Trade premium impact data

Reviewer's Feedback Form

Your feedback directly shapes the Learn.WitUS curriculum. Please complete this form after using the materials with students.

DIGITAL VERSION: Scan the QR code below or visit the link provided by your BVC contact. Responses feed directly into a shared spreadsheet for curriculum improvement.

[QR CODE]

About You

1. Subject you teach:

2. Grade level(s) in this pilot:

3. Approximate number of students who used this material:

About the Materials

4. Which segment(s) or activities did you use?

5. Did students have sufficient background knowledge to engage? What was missing or what helped?

6. Were the Indiana Standards alignments accurate for how you teach this standard?

Student Engagement

7. Scale 1 to 5: How well did the episode hold student attention? (1 = struggled, 5 = highly engaged.) Notes:

8. What specific activity or discussion moment generated the most student response?

Usability

9. Would you use this as a standalone lesson, a unit anchor, or a recurring series? Why?

10. The single change that would make this most usable in your classroom next year:

Overall

11. Would you recommend this curriculum to a colleague? What would you say?

Responses are confidential and used only to improve Learn.WitUS curriculum. Thank you for your time and expertise. Anthony McDonald, Better Vice Club